

Excess and Oscillation: Alternate Anatomical Architectures

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Abstract

The digital is not only the realm of the virtual, but also generates alternative embodiments. Being digital means the body inhabits a flattened ontology of interacting algorithms, machines, instruments, networks, ecologies and other bodies, organisms and objects. There is no privileging of the human, rather the body becomes a component in an extended operational system of human metabolism, machine musculature and computational programming. What becomes apparent now is not the body's identity, but rather its connectivity, not its mobility or location but rather its interface.

Performing increasingly remotely, presence becomes problematic. Presence is marked by a double absence. Or perhaps absence is marked by a double presence. We are neither all-here-now, nor there all-of-the-time, but partly here sometimes and partly somewhere else at other times. There is an increasing and seamless oscillation from offline and online operation. The increasing speed of oscillation blurs any meaningful distinction between the actual and the virtual. We now navigate from cosmological deep time, to physical nano scales to virtual non-places. The body inhabits abstract realms of the highly hypothetical and of streaming subjectivity. A hyper-human that becomes less than the sum of its hyper-links and more than its attachments and implants. The body performs beyond the boundaries of its skin and beyond the local space it inhabits. Augmented and amplified, the body is now in excess of its biology with the proliferation of micro scaled and biocompatible sensors, implants and computational systems. And with nano scaling, there is an urge to internalise technology to create a better surveillance and early alert warning system for the body.

The body has become a contemporary chimera of meat, metal and code. Subjectively, the body experiences itself as an extruded system, rather than an enclosed structure. The self becomes situated beyond the skin, and the body is emptied. But this emptiness is not an emptiness of lack but rather a radical emptiness through excess. An emptiness from the extrusion and extension of its capabilities, its augmented sensory antennae and its increasingly remote functioning.

In this age of body hacking, gene mapping, prosthetic augmentation, organ swapping, face transplants and synthetic skin, what it means to be a body and what it means to be human and what generates aliveness and agency becomes problematic. At the time when the individual body is threatened existentially by fatally being infected by biological viruses, the human species is confronted by

the more pervasive and invasive ontological risk of infection by its techno-digital artifacts and entities. What it means to be human is perhaps not to remain human at all.

CCS Concepts

• Applied computing → Performing arts.

Keywords

digital, connectivity, excess, chimera, augmentation

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Biography



Photo Credit: Damith Herath

Stelarc's projects explore alternative anatomical architectures. He has performed with a Third Hand, an Extended Arm, a Stomach Sculpture, a Prosthetic Head, with industrial robot arms, exoskeletons and robots. He has exhibited in Japan, Korea, China, Europe, the USA, South America and Australia. In 2006 an ear was surgically constructed on his arm. He participated in the Adelaide Biennial of Australian Art in 2020. He is acknowledged internationally as a pioneer in Performance Art, Media Arts and within the Augmented Humans research community.

He has had Residencies, Visiting Artist and Visiting Research positions at Carnegie Mellon University, Pittsburgh; Nottingham Trent University, Nottingham; Brunel University, London; Ohio State University, Columbus; University of Michigan, Michigan; Monash

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University, Melbourne; Curtin University, Perth; Keio University, Tokyo and the Academy of Fine Arts, Krakow. He has given presentations in other major universities and art schools in Europe, Asia, the USA and Australia. He has also given keynotes at major international forums, symposiums and conferences.

In 1996 he was made an Honorary Professor of Art and Robotics, Carnegie Mellon University and in 2002 was awarded an Honorary

Doctor of Laws by Monash University. In 2010 he was awarded the Ars Electronica Golden Nica Hybrid Arts Prize. In 2015 he received the Australia Council's Emerging and Experimental Arts Award. In 2016 he was awarded an Honorary Doctorate from the Ionian University, Corfu. In 2023 he was awarded an Honorary Doctorate from the Academy of Fine Arts, Krakow. His artwork is represented by Scott Livesey Galleries, Melbourne.